ADVISORY

TAU/ADV/012 | Dated 16th March 2026

गृह मंत्रालय
MINISTRY OF
HOME AFFAIRS

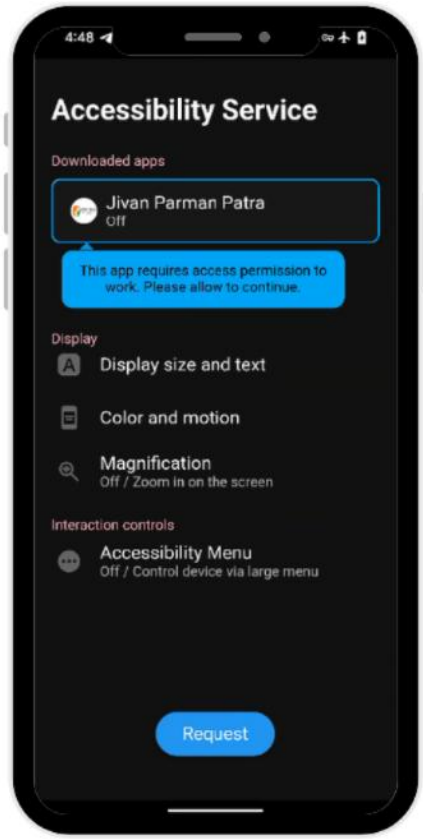
Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre

Android malware mis-using accessibility permission for persistence & total device control – That won't uninstall: Android God Mode

The National Cybercrime Threat Analytics Unit (NCTAU) has observed a sharp rise in highly sophisticated Android malware variants, technically classified as "**Android God Mode**" threats. These malicious apps convincingly impersonate banking, public, and utility services, including "SBI YONO", "Jivan Parman Patra" (Digital Life Certificate), "RTO Challan" and various "Customer Support" applications. By coercing users into granting elevated Android permissions, these threats achieve **near-total control over the device**, enabling stealthy overlay attacks and the real-time theft of sensitive financial and personal information. At the core of this activity is the systematic abuse of Android's **Accessibility** Services, which are being exploited at scale to compromise android users.

MODUS OPERANDI

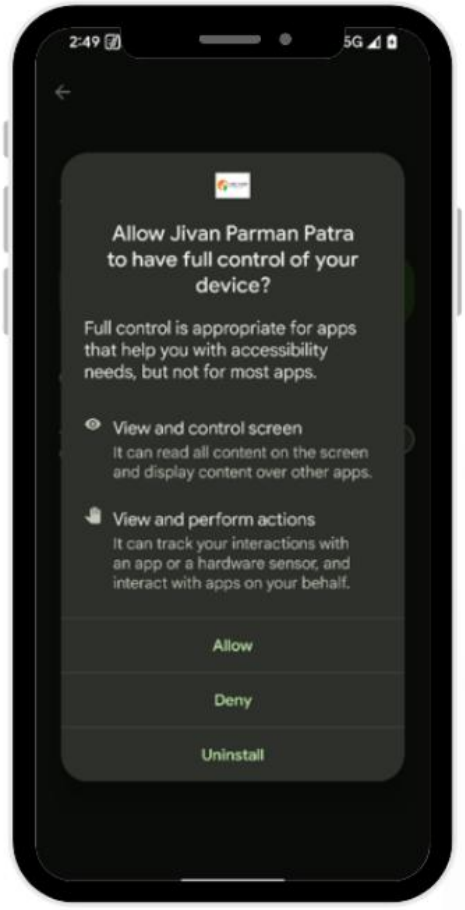
- **Distribution via Droppers:** The malicious Android (.apk) file is initially delivered via phishing links or through WhatsApp as a dropper application. This dropper, which deceptively masquerades as Google Play Services, subsequently installs the actual malware on the device. It utilizes advanced evasion tactics, including zero-length base APKs and split DEX files, to bypass standard security detections.
- **Deceptive Permission Acquisition**: Upon installation, the application persistently prompts the user to enable Accessibility Services, often redirecting the user to the device's Accessibility Settings under the pretext of being required for the app's "essential" functionality. Additionally, the application manipulates user consent to set itself as the default launcher, thereby gaining further control over the device.
- **Persistence:** These malwares features anti-hibernation exemptions (no launcher icon) to remain hidden and resident. These applications are designed to attempt reinstallation from device backups if uninstallation is detected.



PERMISSIONS ABUSED

The following aggressive services and permissions are used to facilitate a total device breach:

- **Accessibility Services:** Grants the malware full visibility and control over on screen UI elements, allowing it to read text from other apps, observe what the user taps or types, and simulate user actions (clicks, scrolls, text entry). Once enabled, it can auto approve permission dialogs (activating READ_SMS, SEND_SMS, CALL_PHONE, SYSTEM_ALERT_WINDOW, CAMERA READ_CONTACTS, etc.), drive the UI of banking and social media apps to perform fraudulent actions, and block or bypass any attempt by the victim to revoke permissions or uninstall the app.



- **READ_SMS / SEND_SMS:** Used to intercept and redirect all SMS, including One-Time Passwords (OTPs), enabling unauthorized financial transactions and social media account takeover.
- **CALL_PHONE:** Exploited to initiate fraudulent call forwarding (linked to USSD account takeover scams) without user awareness.
- **SYSTEM_ALERT_WINDOW:** Allows the malware to draw overlays over banking or settings apps, rendering legitimate "Cancel" or "Deny" buttons invisible or useless.
- **READ_CONTACTS / WRITE_CONTACTS:** Facilitates the exfiltration of the user's contact list for further social engineering or secondary phishing attacks.
- **CAMERA:** Grants unauthorized background access to the device camera, leading to a complete breach of physical privacy.

COMPREHENSIVE REMOVAL OF MALWARE

Ensure app installations are done only through verified sources, prefer the Google Play Store or other official platforms.

Use the steps outlined below to remove the malware, if malware is present on the device.

1. **Boot into Safe Mode**
    a. **Safe Mode** disables third-party apps and their malicious overlays, making it the most effective way to bypass accessibility-based blocks.
    b. **How to boot:** Press the Power button, then long-press Power Off until the Reboot to Safe Mode prompt appears.
    c. **Uninstall malicious apps:** Go to **Settings > Apps > [Select the app] > Uninstall**. Ensure all suspected or related malicious applications are removed.



2. **Change the Default Launcher**
    a. As an alternative, navigate to **Settings > Apps > Default Apps > Home App and switch to a system launcher**.
    b. This can help break the malware's control over the device interface.
    c. Then uninstall the malicious apps: **Settings > Apps > [Select the app] > Uninstall**. Remove all related malicious applications.
3. **Review Device Admin and Accessibility Permissions**
    a. **Go to Settings > Security > Device Admin Apps and Settings > Accessibility** to ensure no suspicious or unauthorized services remain active.
4. **Network Hygiene (USSD Check):** To counter call forwarding enabled by the CALL_PHONE permission, **dial the USSD code ##002#** instantly cancel all active call forwarding services.
5. **Final Verification**
    a. After uninstalling, reboot the device normally and review the installed apps list again under **Settings > Apps.**
    b. If the malicious apps reappear, perform a Factory Data Reset to fully restore the device.

Report any fraudulent applications or any scam incident immediately on **1930** or **www.cybercrime.gov.in.**